

The Outcasts of Poker Flat

Bret Harte · 1869

First published: Overland Monthly, Jan 1869

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

Cover: Gustave Caillebotte, Paris Street; Rainy Day (1877). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons).

Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/Luck_of_Roaring_Camp_(1870)/The_Outcasts_of_Poker_Flat (revision 7458162), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 9–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Outcasts of Poker Flat suggest about redemption among outcasts?
- What does The Outcasts of Poker Flat suggest about community and morality?
- What does The Outcasts of Poker Flat suggest about nature's indifference?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	The Outcasts of Poker Flat	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*redemption among outcasts* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: The Outcasts of Poker Flat

Focus: moral worth found among those society rejects

Content note (a prostitute and a gambler as characters, death by starvation and cold, a suicide, suicide): Sensitive content: A prostitute and a gambler as characters; death by starvation and cold; a suicide. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes a prostitute and a gambler as characters; death by starvation and cold; a suicide. Support is available if this is hard to read.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this story is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

In 1850, a vigilance committee in the mining camp of Poker Flat expels gambler John Oakhurst, 'The Duchess', Mother Shipton and drunken Uncle Billy. On the trail they meet innocent young Tom Simson and his fiancée Piney. Snowed in, Uncle Billy steals the mules. Mother Shipton starves herself to save food for Piney; Tom goes for help. Oakhurst shoots himself under a pine; the Duchess and Piney die in each other's arms.

Background: Published in the Overland Monthly in 1869, set in California's 1850 Gold Rush camps, where vigilance committees administered rough justice.

Significance: A key local-color story that made Harte famous.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: Can a person whom society calls 'bad' act with true goodness? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes a prostitute and a gambler as characters; death by starvation and cold; a suicide. Support is available if this is hard to read. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are decreasing, overruled, defection, wrestled, amphitheatre. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "The third day came, and the sun, looking through the white-curtained valley, saw the outcasts divide their slowly decreasing store of provisions for the morning meal." In this sentence it means: becoming smaller or less. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of The Outcasts of Poker Flat would have known. Published in the Overland Monthly in 1869, set in California's 1850 Gold Rush camps, where vigilance committees administered rough justice. Why does this story matter? A key local-color story that made Harte famous. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for characterization.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "Mr." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to moral worth found among those society rejects? I circle "overruled", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find characterization, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for characterization.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of characterization. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *Mr. Oakhurst was right in supposing that he was included in this category. A few of the committee had urged hanging him as a possible example, and a sure method of reimbursing themselves from his pockets of the sums he had won from them. "It's agin justice," said Jim Wheeler, "to let this yer young man from Roaring Camp —an entire stranger—carry away our money." But a crude sentiment of equity residing in the breasts of those who had been fortunate enough to win from Mr. Oakhurst overruled this narrower local prejudice.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Characterization, Irony, Setting: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The Outcasts of Poker Flat develops the idea of moral worth found among those society rejects. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to redemption among outcasts? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about moral worth found among those society rejects, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes moral worth found among those society rejects. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
decreasing (verb)	becoming smaller or less	*The third day came, and the sun, looking through the white-curtained valley, saw the outcasts divide their slowly decreasing store of provisions for the morning meal.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
overruled (verb)	outvoted; overridden	*Oakhurst overruled this narrower local prejudice.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
defection (noun)	leaving one person or side for another	*He dropped a warning to the Duchess and Mother Shipton, who of course knew the facts of their associate's defection. "They'll find out the truth about us all when they find out anything," he added, significantly, "and there's no good frightening them now."*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
wrestled (verb)	combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force	*Trojan bully and wily Greek wrestled in the winds, and the great pines in the cañon seemed to bow to the wrath of the son of Peleus.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
amphitheatre (noun)	a sloping gallery with seats for spectators (as in an operating room or theater)	*A wooded amphitheatre, surrounded on three sides by precipitous cliffs of naked granite, sloped gently toward the crest of another precipice that overlooked the valley.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
	adding up (to)		

amounting (verb)		*He had met him some months before over a "little game," and had, with perfect equanimity, won the entire fortune—amounting to some forty dollars—of that guileless youth.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
patched (adjective)	hastily put together	*The ruined cabin, patched and covered with pine-boughs, was set apart for the ladies.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
equanimity (noun)	steadiness of mind under stress	*Yet he could not help feeling the want of that excitement which, singularly enough, was most conducive to that calm equanimity for which he was notorious.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
joining (verb)	become part of; become a member of a group or organization	*But the crowning festivity of the evening was reached in a rude camp-meeting hymn, which the lovers, joining hands, sang with great earnestness and vociferation.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
diversion (noun)	an activity that diverts or amuses or stimulates	*But music failed to fill entirely the aching void left by insufficient food, and a new diversion was proposed by Piney,—story-telling.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Can a person whom society calls 'bad' act with true goodness?
2. Where does characterization appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with redemption among outcasts?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Why are the outcasts expelled? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A committee is cleaning the town of 'improper persons'
2. What is John Oakhurst's profession? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Gambler
3. What does Uncle Billy do? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Steals the mules and leaves
4. How does Mother Shipton die? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: She starves herself so Piney can eat
5. What is found on the pine tree? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A card pinned as Oakhurst's epitaph

6. Retell the three most important events of “The Outcasts of Poker Flat” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: In 1850, a vigilance committee in the mining camp of Poker Flat expels gambler John Oakhurst, 'The Duchess', Mother Shipton and drunken Uncle Billy. On the trail they meet innocent young Tom Simson and his fiancée Piney. Snowed in, Uncle Billy steals the mules. Mother Shipton starves herself to save food for Piney; Tom goes for help. Oakhurst shoots himself under a pine; the Duchess and Piney die…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Outcasts of Poker Flat”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Outcasts of Poker Flat” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “The third day came, and the sun, looking through the white-curtained valley, saw the outcasts divide their slowly decreasing store of provisions for the morning meal.” What does “decreasing” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: decreasing: becoming smaller or less.
10. Reread: “Oakhurst overruled this narrower local prejudice.” What does “overruled” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: overruled: outvoted; overridden.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Outcasts of Poker Flat” suggest about moral worth found among those society rejects? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A key local-color story that made Harte famous.
2. Find one example of characterization in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
3. How does the irony in this story shape what we understand about moral worth found among those society rejects? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
4. In the passage that begins “Mr.”, why might Harte have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Outcasts of Poker Flat”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: In 1850, a vigilance committee in the mining camp of Poker Flat expels gambler John Oakhurst, 'The Duchess', Mother Shipton and drunken Uncle Billy. On the trail they meet innocent young Tom Simson and his fiancée Piney. Snowed in, Uncle Billy steals the mules. Mother Shipton starves herself to…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Outcasts of Poker Flat” set up that the rest of The Outcasts of Poker Flat will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

8. The bell-ringer asked: “Can a person whom society calls 'bad' act with true goodness?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does setting appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with redemption among outcasts? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
10. Background: Published in the Overland Monthly in 1869, set in California's 1850 Gold Rush camps, where vigilance committees administered rough justice. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A key local-color story that made Harte famous.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Outcasts of Poker Flat” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about moral worth found among those society rejects? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about “The Outcasts of Poker Flat”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to community and morality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Harte need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the characterization in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how “The Outcasts of Poker Flat” treats moral worth found among those society rejects with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Outcasts of Poker Flat see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve redemption among outcasts? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about moral worth found among those society rejects? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Bret Harte about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true
- Also notice **Setting**: where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling

Chapter quiz

1. Why are the outcasts expelled?
   A. They cheated at cards on Sunday
   B. They started a fire
   C. A committee is cleaning the town of 'improper persons'
   D. They stole gold
2. What is John Oakhurst's profession?
   A. Sheriff
   B. Preacher
   C. Miner
   D. Gambler
3. What does Uncle Billy do?
   A. Builds a cabin
   B. Steals the mules and leaves
   C. Goes for help
   D. Dies first
4. How does Mother Shipton die?
   A. She freezes on the trail
   B. She is shot
   C. She starves herself so Piney can eat
   D. She falls
5. What is found on the pine tree?
   A. A map
   B. Tom's knife
   C. A card pinned as Oakhurst's epitaph
   D. A letter to Piney
6. In the line “The third day came, and the sun, looking through the white-curtained valley, saw the outcasts divide their slowly decreasing store of provisions for the morning meal.”, what does “decreasing” most nearly mean?
   A. outvoted; overridden
   B. becoming smaller or less
   C. leaving one person or side for another
   D. combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force

7. In the line “Oakhurst overruled this narrower local prejudice.”, what does “overruled” most nearly mean?
   A. becoming smaller or less
   B. combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force
   C. outvoted; overridden
   D. leaving one person or side for another

Answer key: 1. C (A committee is cleaning the town of 'improper persons'); 2. D (Gambler); 3. B (Steals the mules and leaves); 4. C (She starves herself so Piney can eat); 5. C (A card pinned as Oakhurst's epitaph); 6. B (becoming smaller or less); 7. C (outvoted; overridden)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.3, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Outcasts of Poker Flat,” how does Harte show moral worth found among those society rejects? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In The Outcasts of Poker Flat, how does Harte develop the idea of moral worth found among those society rejects? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Outcasts of Poker Flat develops the idea of moral worth found among those society rejects. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Outcasts of Poker Flat (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of moral worth found among those society rejects. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Outcasts of Poker Flat suggests about moral worth found among those society rejects. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's characterization and irony), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Bret Harte uses characterization in The Outcasts of Poker Flat to complicate the reader's understanding of moral worth found among those society rejects. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Outcasts of Poker Flat within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of moral worth found among those society rejects responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Outcasts of Poker Flat alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of moral worth found among those society rejects follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Outcasts of Poker Flat and its treatment of moral worth found among those society rejects. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's characterization and irony, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Outcasts of Poker Flat as evidence for a larger claim about moral worth found among those society rejects in The Outcasts of Poker Flat. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Outcasts of Poker Flat as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of moral worth found among those society rejects. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Outcasts of Poker Flat.

SAT-style questions

1. *He dropped a warning to the Duchess and Mother Shipton, who of course knew the facts of their associate's defection. "They'll find out the truth about us all when they find out anything," he added, significantly, "and there's no good frightening them now."*

   As used in the text, what does the word “defection” most nearly mean?

   A. an activity that diverts or amuses or stimulates

   B. leaving one person or side for another

   C. become part of; become a member of a group or organization

   D. steadiness of mind under stress

2. *Mr. Oakhurst was right in supposing that he was included in this category. A few of the committee had urged hanging him as a possible example, and a sure method of reimbursing themselves from his pockets of the sums he had won from them. "It's agin justice," said Jim Wheeler, "to let this yer young man from Roaring Camp —an entire stranger—carry away our money." But a crude sentiment of equity residing in the breasts of those who had been fortunate enough to win from Mr. Oakhurst overruled this narrower local prejudice.*

Which choice best states a central concern of "The Outcasts of Poker Flat"?

A. Moral worth found among those society rejects

B. A woman's brief taste of freedom

C. Greed that grasps more than a person needs

D. Self-destruction and the urge to do wrong

SAT key: 1. B (leaving one person or side for another); 2. A (Moral worth found among those society rejects)

Whole-book test

The Outcasts of Poker Flat: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. Why are the outcasts expelled?
   A. They cheated at cards on Sunday
   B. They started a fire
   C. A committee is cleaning the town of 'improper persons'
   D. They stole gold
2. What is John Oakhurst's profession?
   A. Sheriff
   B. Preacher
   C. Miner
   D. Gambler
3. What does Uncle Billy do?
   A. Builds a cabin
   B. Steals the mules and leaves
   C. Goes for help
   D. Dies first
4. How does Mother Shipton die?
   A. She freezes on the trail
   B. She is shot
   C. She starves herself so Piney can eat
   D. She falls
5. What is found on the pine tree?
   A. A map
   B. Tom's knife
   C. A card pinned as Oakhurst's epitaph
   D. A letter to Piney
6. In the line “The third day came, and the sun, looking through the white-curtained valley, saw the outcasts divide their slowly decreasing store of provisions for the morning meal.”, what does “decreasing” most nearly mean?
   A. outvoted; overridden
   B. becoming smaller or less
   C. leaving one person or side for another
   D. combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force

7. In the line “Oakhurst overruled this narrower local prejudice.”, what does “overruled” most nearly mean?
   A. becoming smaller or less
   B. combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force
   C. outvoted; overridden
   D. leaving one person or side for another
8. As used in the story (“The third day came, and the sun, looking through the white-curtained valley, saw the outcasts divide their slowly decreasing store of provis”), what does “decreasing” mean?
   A. becoming smaller or less
   B. a sloping gallery with seats for spectators (as in an operating room or theater)
   C. steadiness of mind under stress
   D. outvoted; overridden
9. As used in the story (“Oakhurst overruled this narrower local prejudice.”), what does “overruled” mean?
   A. adding up (to)
   B. outvoted; overridden
   C. become part of; become a member of a group or organization
   D. leaving one person or side for another
10. As used in the story (“He dropped a warning to the Duchess and Mother Shipton, who of course knew the facts of their associate's defection. "They'll find out the t”), what does “defection” mean?
    A. hastily put together
    B. an activity that diverts or amuses or stimulates
    C. leaving one person or side for another
    D. combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force
11. As used in the story (“Trojan bully and wily Greek wrestled in the winds, and the great pines in the cañon seemed to bow to the wrath of the son of Peleus.”), what does “wrestled” mean?
    A. steadiness of mind under stress
    B. becoming smaller or less
    C. a sloping gallery with seats for spectators (as in an operating room or theater)
    D. combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force
12. As used in the story (“A wooded amphitheatre, surrounded on three sides by precipitous cliffs of naked granite, sloped gently toward the crest of another precipice”), what does “amphitheatre” mean?
    A. a sloping gallery with seats for spectators (as in an operating room or theater)
    B. become part of; become a member of a group or organization
    C. outvoted; overridden
    D. adding up (to)

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how redemption among outcasts develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

2. Explain how community and morality develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how nature's indifference develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (redemption among outcasts, community and morality, nature's indifference) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. C (A committee is cleaning the town of 'improper persons'); 2. D (Gambler); 3. B (Steals the mules and leaves); 4. C (She starves herself so Piney can eat); 5. C (A card pinned as Oakhurst's epitaph); 6. B (becoming smaller or less); 7. C (outvoted; overridden); 8. A (becoming smaller or less); 9. B (outvoted; overridden); 10. C (leaving one person or side for another); 11. D (combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force); 12. A (a sloping gallery with seats for spectators (as in an operating room or theater))

Essay assignments

Essay: Redemption among outcasts

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Outcasts of Poker Flat teaches about redemption among outcasts. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Bret Harte develops redemption among outcasts in The Outcasts of Poker Flat. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Bret Harte develops redemption among outcasts across The Outcasts of Poker Flat. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Outcasts of Poker Flat (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of redemption among outcasts. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of redemption among outcasts in The Outcasts of Poker Flat. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Bret Harte's choices in The Outcasts of Poker Flat (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of redemption among outcasts, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Outcasts of Poker Flat's treatment of redemption among outcasts in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on redemption among outcasts in The Outcasts of Poker Flat that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on redemption among outcasts in The Outcasts of Poker Flat. Name

your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about redemption among outcasts in The Outcasts of Poker Flat, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on redemption among outcasts in The Outcasts of Poker Flat, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Community and morality

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Outcasts of Poker Flat teaches about community and morality. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Bret Harte develops community and morality in The Outcasts of Poker Flat. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Bret Harte develops community and morality across The Outcasts of Poker Flat. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Outcasts of Poker Flat (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of community and morality. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of community and morality in The Outcasts of Poker Flat. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Bret Harte's choices in The Outcasts of Poker Flat (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of community and morality, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Outcasts of Poker Flat's treatment of community and morality in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on community and morality in The Outcasts of Poker Flat that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on community and morality in The Outcasts of Poker Flat. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about community and morality in The Outcasts of Poker Flat, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on community and morality in The Outcasts of Poker Flat, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Nature's indifference

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Outcasts of Poker Flat teaches about nature's indifference. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Bret Harte develops nature's indifference in The Outcasts of Poker Flat. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Bret Harte develops nature's indifference across The Outcasts of Poker Flat. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Outcasts of Poker Flat (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of nature's indifference. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of nature's indifference in The Outcasts of Poker Flat. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Bret Harte's choices in The Outcasts of Poker Flat (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of nature's indifference, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Outcasts of Poker Flat's treatment of nature's indifference in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on nature's indifference in The Outcasts of Poker Flat that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on nature's indifference in The Outcasts of Poker Flat. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about nature's indifference in The Outcasts of Poker Flat, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on nature's indifference in The Outcasts of Poker Flat, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary, 2026-10-20); other words are student look-ups. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.